

The Ten-Point Menstrual-Dignity Check

A twenty-minute self-assessment for schools

Treasured Vessels Girls' Centre

Walukuba-Masese Road, Jinja, Uganda

treasuredvesselsuganda.org

Tick only what is true today, not what is planned. **A school that scores four is not a bad school.** It is a school that now knows which four things to fix first. No names, no photographs, no need to send this to anyone.

- 1 Emergency supplies she can get without an ordeal** ☐
Test: would a thirteen-year-old actually go and ask? A locked cupboard in a male teacher's office does not count.
- 2 Water and soap, at the toilets, all day** ☐
Not water at a tank across the compound. Not soap that ran out in February.
- 3 Toilets that are private, sex-separated and lockable** ☐
A door that closes, a latch that works, walls she cannot be seen over, enough light.
- 4 Somewhere to change that is not a cubicle with a queue** ☐
A partitioned corner of an existing room is enough. It does not need to be a new building.
- 5 Storage, and somewhere private to dry** ☐
A reusable pad that cannot be dried out of sight will be dried badly, hidden damp, or abandoned.
- 6 Disposal that actually works** ☐
A covered bin in each cubicle, emptied by someone whose job it explicitly is.
- 7 Pain taken seriously** ☐
Simple relief available, permission to rest briefly, and staff who do not treat period pain as an excuse.
- 8 Accurate education, including for the boys** ☐
Taught before it starts, not after. A school that teaches only the girls has taught the wrong half.
- 9 One named adult every girl can identify** ☐
Usually the senior woman teacher. Name her, then give her supplies, a small budget and a private room.
- 10 A referral route for when it is not normal** ☐
Somewhere to send a girl with severe pain, very heavy bleeding, or bleeding that will not stop.

Score today _____ out of 10

Date _____ Completed by _____

Fix the cheapest failing point first. It is very often the soap.

What to buy, and what to fix

Two lists that behave very differently

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CONSUMABLES

Recur every term, forever

- Disposable pads for the emergency stock
- Soap
- Simple pain relief
- Replacement reusable kits as they wear out
- Bin liners

A one-off gift solves one term, then stops.

INFRASTRUCTURE

Bought once, then maintained

- A door, and a latch that works
- Water tank or connection near the latrines
- A partition to make a changing space
- Covered bins, and a private drying line
- Locks and lighting

Still there in five years.

Infrastructure is the better gift. A school can usually carry the consumables once the infrastructure exists. It is almost never the other way round.

THE THREE MOST COMMON FAILURES, AND WHAT TO DO

No soap. The cheapest and most frequently missing item on the whole list, and the one that makes most of the others unusable. Put it in the termly budget as a named line rather than leaving it to whoever remembers. Soap on a rope, tied at the tap, survives longer than a loose bar.

No door or no latch. A latrine without a working door is not a facility with a minor defect. For this purpose it is not a facility at all. This is usually a carpenter and an afternoon, and it unlocks points three, four and six at once.

Nowhere to dry. The problem most often reported by senior women teachers and the one most often left out of programme budgets. A screened line in a corner the boys do not pass is enough. Without it, do not distribute reusable kits: disposables will serve the girls better.

WHAT THE NATIONAL GUIDANCE ALREADY SAYS

The Ministry of Education and Sports circular of 2015 called for clean, private toilets, a regular supply of water and soap, emergency supplies of pads and painkillers, training for teachers and inspectors, and the involvement of parents. Fuller Menstrual Health Guidelines for schools have since been published. A review of 137 Ugandan schools found **94% had received the 2015 circular and 17% were implementing it.** The gap has never been the guidance.

IF YOUR SCHOOL IS IN OR NEAR JINJA

We provide menstrual health education for girls and boys, reusable kits, and help completing this check. There is no charge.

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We do not photograph students receiving supplies, and we will not ask you to arrange it. A completed anonymous check tells us more than a distribution photograph ever did.